

Afghanistan Humanitarian Crisis: Key Focus Areas and Strategies

Economic Recovery

Challenges: Afghanistan's economy suffered a severe collapse after the Taliban takeover in August 2021. Before the takeover, the country was **75% dependent on foreign aid**, which funded public salaries and services

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. When donor support was cut off and **about \$9 billion in Afghan foreign reserves were frozen** abroad

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, millions lost their incomes virtually overnight. By early 2024, **approximately 85% of Afghans live on less than one dollar a day**, reflecting widespread poverty

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. The economy has stabilized somewhat at a very low level – the World Bank notes **modest GDP growth (~2.7%)** after the initial contraction, but this has only regained *10%* of the output lost since 2020

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. Economic activity remains hamstrung by **fiscal constraints, a huge trade deficit, and almost no capacity for public investment**

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. With the Taliban government unrecognized, the central bank is cut off from the international system, limiting liquidity and foreign trade

Strategies for Improvement: Realistic steps to revive Afghanistan's economy focus on humanitarian relief and basic functionality rather than large-scale development. **Injecting liquidity through international aid** is crucial – humanitarian cash programs and salary payments for essential workers can restore some purchasing power

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. **Unlocking frozen assets for strictly humanitarian uses** is one proposal. For example, funds seized from the Afghan central bank could be transferred into U.N.-administered trusts to purchase food and medicine, rather than handed to the de facto authorities. **Trade initiatives** can also help: regional countries have maintained commerce with Afghanistan – Iran, for instance, is working on port and railway projects (Chabahar port and rail links) and crop substitution to curb the illicit economy

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. Supporting such projects could integrate Afghanistan into regional supply chains and provide jobs.

Economic reforms under Taliban rule are limited, but some measures have modestly improved revenue (e.g. anti-corruption efforts at customs). The **World Bank emphasizes enabling women's economic participation** and investing in human capital as essential for any sustained recovery

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. Reversing bans on women workers would immediately expand the labor force and productivity. Slovenia can support policies in the UN Security Council (UNSC) that tie any future development assistance or sanctions relief to concrete economic reforms – for example, urging the Taliban to reopen banks and allow women to work, in exchange for technical support to bolster banking operations. Slovenia could also back the creation of a UNSC “**Working Group on Afghan Economic Recovery**” to coordinate aid, infrastructure projects, and advice for Afghanistan’s economy (as Slovenia’s delegation has suggested) to ensure international efforts are cohesive.

Role of International Aid: International financial institutions and donors remain cautious but not absent. The EU, World Bank, and Asian Development Bank have all crafted mechanisms to aid Afghans without legitimizing the Taliban. Slovenia can champion **increased funding to U.N. agencies and NGOs** operating in Afghanistan, ensuring that lifesaving assistance also shores up the local economy (for instance by hiring local staff and purchasing Afghan produce when possible). **Trade facilitation** is another angle – Slovenia and EU partners might support initiatives for duty-free access to Afghan goods or corridor projects that connect Afghan traders to global markets. In summary, while full economic normalization is unrealistic under the current regime, targeted steps – humanitarian cash infusions, regional trade support, and conditional engagement on economic management – can mitigate collapse and lay groundwork for future recovery

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. Slovenia should support these pragmatic efforts in line with its commitment to help the Afghan people without empowering the Taliban.

Human and Women's Rights

Current Situation: The human rights landscape in Afghanistan is dire, with **women and girls bearing the brunt of Taliban repression**. Since 2021, the Taliban have barred girls from secondary and higher education and pushed women out of most jobs and public life. It has now been **over 1,100 days** of such “blatant abuse and trampling of women’s rights,” as Slovenia’s Foreign Minister Tanja Fajon noted

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. The Taliban’s decrees – recently codified into a so-called *morality law* – amount to a “**gender apartheid**”, systematically persecuting women for their gender

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. Women are forbidden from school beyond age 12 and cannot work in NGOs, government, many industries, or even move freely without a male guardian

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. These edicts not only destroy women's freedoms but also **harm the entire society's future**, depriving Afghanistan of half its talent. Outside of women's rights, the broader human rights situation is also alarming: dissent is crushed, media freedom is curtailed, and there are credible reports of extrajudicial killings, especially of former officials and minorities. The U.N. High Commissioner for Refugees has identified Afghanistan as "*one of the world's most urgent crises*" due to **human rights violations, economic instability, acute hunger, and natural disasters** – a combination that can threaten regional stability

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International Frameworks and Best Practices: The international community has condemned the Taliban's actions and laid out clear expectations. The UNSC unanimously passed **Resolution 2681 (2023)**, which "**called for a swift reversal of all restrictions on women's rights**" in Afghanistan

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. This resolution – supported by Slovenia – sends a strong signal that Taliban policies are unacceptable. Moreover, multiple countries (including Slovenia during its September 2024 Security Council presidency) have raised the possibility that the Taliban's gender persecution could constitute crimes against humanity under the **Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court**

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. Beyond U.N. resolutions, the **Women, Peace and Security (WPS)** agenda offers a framework: U.N. member states have affirmed that women's participation is crucial to peace and stability. Slovenia joined a **joint Security Council stakeout** in 2024 declaring that "*the future of any country, including Afghanistan, cannot be prosperous unless it is inclusive*" and urging the Taliban to "**immediately end all discriminatory practices**" against women and girls

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. This reflects best practices of unified diplomatic pressure.

Successful approaches in other contexts can be applied here. One is sustained **monitoring and reporting**: a U.N. Special Rapporteur for Afghanistan's human rights was appointed and should continue to document abuses, keeping global attention and pressure. Another is leveraging influential Muslim-majority countries and scholars to challenge the Taliban's policies on Islamic grounds – for instance, the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) has called the bans on girls' education un-Islamic and appointed an envoy to engage the Taliban. **Targeted sanctions** are also a tool: the UNSC can impose travel bans or asset freezes on individual Taliban leaders responsible for egregious violations (some such sanctions already exist for terrorism reasons). However, care must be taken to avoid harming the population; thus, targeted measures coupled with humanitarian carve-outs are best practice. International humanitarian organizations, despite restrictions, are finding creative ways to support Afghan women – for example, *UNICEF's "secret schools"* or community-based education programs allow some girls to keep learning quietly. Supporting local **women-led NGOs** (many now operating from exile or underground) is another best practice to maintain civil society. Slovenia can advocate these measures in the UNSC: call for regular reviews of Taliban's human rights record, support resolutions that condemn abuses, and ensure any engagement with Afghan authorities is conditional on **measurable human rights improvements**. In essence, Slovenia's stance is to be "*the voice of oppressed women and girls in Afghanistan*"

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– meaning Slovenia will push the UNSC to prioritize human rights in all decisions on Afghanistan. Only by upholding international norms – such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and conventions on women’s rights – can there be hope for improving conditions on the ground.

Immediate Humanitarian Aid

Urgent Needs: Afghanistan faces an acute humanitarian catastrophe. Over **23.7 million people (more than half the population)** require humanitarian assistance for basic survival

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. Of these, nearly **15 million suffer acute food insecurity**, and about **3 million children are acutely malnourished or at risk of starvation**

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. The country’s healthcare system is on the brink of collapse – hospitals lack medicines, and many clinics that were donor-funded have closed, leaving millions without care. Shelter and water are also critical concerns: many Afghans lack adequate housing or clean water, especially displaced families. Years of war and recent natural disasters have compounded the crisis. In the winter of 2023–2024, **harsh cold and a series of earthquakes (such as the major quakes in Herat province)** left tens of thousands in need of emergency shelter

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. Meanwhile, a new wave of displacement is occurring: since September 2023, **over 618,000 Afghans have returned or been expelled from Pakistan** amid crackdowns, arriving in Afghanistan often homeless and destitute

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. These returnees add to an internally displaced population in need of food, warmth, and jobs. In sum, Afghanistan’s immediate needs span **food, healthcare, nutrition, shelter, clean water, and basic supplies** to keep people alive.

Humanitarian Response: Despite challenges, humanitarian organizations are on the ground trying to deliver aid. In 2023, **over 28 million Afghans received some form of assistance** – an enormous effort led by the U.N. and NGOs

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. However, funding and access remain problematic. The U.N.’s 2024 Humanitarian Response Plan for Afghanistan was only **21% funded as of mid-2024**, causing agencies like the World Food Programme to cut food rations

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. Aid workers also face Taliban-imposed obstacles, notably the **ban on Afghan women working for U.N. agencies and NGOs**, which OCHA warns is hampering aid delivery

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. Still, many organizations have found ways to keep operating (often by using male-female “mahram” teams or negotiating exceptions in health and education sectors). International and regional actors must step up to prevent a complete catastrophe. **Slovenia and other UNSC members can push for immediate measures:** urging donor countries to fully fund the U.N.’s appeals and **close the \$3+ billion funding gap** press.un.org, and calling on the Taliban to grant unimpeded access to humanitarian workers of **all genders**. Notably, UNSC Resolution 2615 (2021) already carved out humanitarian exceptions to sanctions, allowing aid to flow; Slovenia should ensure this exception remains and is strengthened so that fears of legal breaches do not impede aid press.un.org.

Coordinating Aid Efforts: A mix of international and regional initiatives is needed. The U.N. continues to lead on humanitarian coordination through its mission (UNAMA) and OCHA, but support from neighboring countries is invaluable. Pakistan and Iran host millions of Afghan refugees and have served as transit hubs for aid – they will require financial help to keep borders open and assist refugees. **Greater responsibility-sharing** is a must: UNHCR emphasizes that the international community needs to help Afghanistan’s neighbors and invest in resilience to prevent further refugee flows

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. Regional organizations like the **OIC and SAARC** (South Asian Association) can also play a role in mobilizing aid from Muslim-majority nations, which might have more influence with the Taliban. Bilaterally, countries like Qatar, Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan have delivered food, energy, and medical aid directly to Afghanistan; Slovenia can encourage the EU to support and upscale such bilateral efforts. One creative approach, as mentioned, is to **use frozen Afghan assets to purchase relief supplies**file-5qtsnewp7oqv1u5ouacvj – for example, using seized central bank funds to buy wheat, which can then be distributed through the World Food Programme. This would inject resources without handing cash to the Taliban.

In UNSC discussions, **Slovenia can advocate a humanitarian “airlift” or corridor system** – akin to past operations – to get food and medicine into remote Afghan regions before next winter. Additionally, protecting humanitarian workers is crucial: Slovenia should support language that condemns interference in aid operations and demands the Taliban **lift the ban on women aid workers for aid to continue**

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. In the immediate term, saving lives is the priority. As Slovenia’s delegation has argued, *“Immediate aid must be given to the millions at risk of famine and to the women who have been so deeply oppressed under Taliban rule”*file-5qtsnewp7oqv1u5ouacvj. This means food on tables, hospitals running, and safe shelters – all achievable if the international community maintains focus and funding despite political differences with those in power. Slovenia’s voice in the Council can help keep that focus on the humanitarian imperative.

Engagement with the Taliban

Backchannel Engagement vs. Recognition: Navigating relations with the Taliban is a delicate balancing act. Slovenia and the wider international community have explicitly **refused to grant formal recognition** to the Taliban regime. At the same time, some level of engagement is unavoidable if we are to deliver aid and influence behavior. The key is to engage *pragmatically* without legitimizing. As the U.N. Special Representative for Afghanistan, Roza Otunbayeva, told the Security Council, “**engagement is not normalization**” – talking to the de facto authorities “**does not mean legitimization of the Taliban**”

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. This principle guides current backchannels. For instance, the U.N. has convened a series of **meetings in Doha** (Qatar) where Taliban representatives meet informally with envoys from various countries. In June 2024, a third such meeting was held to “**reinforce the principles underlining the consensus to engage**” while reiterating that fundamental international expectations (like women’s rights) remain firm

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. These backdoor talks allow dialogue on urgent issues – humanitarian access, security concerns, economic stability – **without implying diplomatic recognition**. Slovenia can support this *Doha process* and similar initiatives that keep channels open. Another form of low-profile engagement is through technical discussions: for example, UNAMA and agencies frequently negotiate with Taliban officials at the working level to resolve practical problems (like reopening a clinic or obtaining permission for a UN flight). Such **confidence-building measures** can yield small concessions. A recent example is health and education: in some provinces, local Taliban authorities quietly allowed **community schools for girls** or permitted women in healthcare roles, due to community pressure and negotiation. Encouraging these local exceptions and expanding them could build trust gradually.

Maintaining Principles: While engaging, the international community must hold clear red lines. The EU **has laid out five benchmarks** for the Taliban (preventing terrorism, respecting human rights – especially women’s rights – forming an inclusive government, allowing free humanitarian access, and permitting freedom of travel for those who wish to leave)

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. Slovenia aligns with this approach: any deeper cooperation depends on Taliban actions. In practice, this means any backchannel contacts should **consistently reiterate demands** such as reopening girls’ schools or ending punitive policies, even if immediate change is unlikely. Small **confidence-building steps** could be pursued: for instance, if the Taliban were to rescind one or two restrictions (say, allowing women to work in humanitarian operations), international actors could respond with a modest concession of their own, like unfreezing a small amount of funds for salaries or providing additional relief in that area. These **step-by-step gestures** build confidence without ever compromising on core principles. It’s a strategy of

incremental reciprocity, not grand bargains. Additionally, **track-two dialogues** (unofficial talks involving former officials, tribal leaders, or NGOs) can run in parallel to official channels. Such dialogues might explore long-term issues – e.g. frameworks for a future political process – in a low-pressure setting, feeding ideas back to official negotiators.

Throughout any engagement, **legal and ethical standards must be upheld**. Slovenia will insist that engagement remain “principled.” This means continued condemnation of abuses even while talking, and no actions that would violate international sanctions or laws. For example, any financial transactions as part of engagement must comply with anti-terrorism financing rules. The UNSC can support the U.N.’s role as a mediator: giving UNAMA a strong mandate to liaise with the de facto authorities on behalf of the international community. Notably, in late 2023 the Council called for the U.N. Secretary-General to **develop a roadmap for dialogue** – a process to outline what the Taliban must do to eventually earn international acceptance

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. Engaging the Taliban also involves regional players: countries like Pakistan, China, Iran, and Russia have more direct influence as they kept their embassies in Kabul. Slovenia can encourage these states to use their channels to press the Taliban on shared concerns (for instance, Pakistan on counterterrorism, Iran on refugee flows, etc.), all while coordinating with Western states. The balance Slovenia seeks is “**critical engagement**” – talk to the Taliban to avert suffering and conflict, but **with no hint of recognition until they meet fundamental international norms**

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. By walking this line, the UNSC can keep Afghanistan on the agenda and possibly nudge the Taliban toward reforms, without abandoning the Afghan people or endorsing an oppressive regime.

Committee Plan for Slovenia (Short-Term vs. Long-Term)

As a member of the Security Council, **Slovenia’s plan** is to pursue a dual-track approach: address immediate humanitarian and human rights crises in the short term, while laying groundwork for sustainable improvements and engagement in the long term. This approach respects Slovenia’s stance of non-recognition of the Taliban and focuses on tangible help for Afghans.

Short-Term Strategies (Immediate Actions)

- **Humanitarian Surge:** Slovenia will urge the UNSC and U.N. members to mount an immediate humanitarian surge. This includes **fully funding U.N. appeals** and possibly organizing an emergency donor conference to plug funding gaps. Slovenia can propose a UNSC **resolution or statement calling for unhindered humanitarian access**, explicitly demanding the Taliban remove barriers like the ban on women aid workers. The goal is to get food, medical supplies, and shelter to those most in need before the next winter. Slovenia also supports innovative delivery methods – for example, **using the World Food Programme’s air bridges** or pre-positioning supplies in neighboring countries for quick transport into Afghanistan. In line with this, Slovenia will highlight the plight of returnees and refugees; it supports increased U.N. assistance to Afghan refugees in Iran and Pakistan, which relieves pressure on Afghanistan itself

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- **Protecting Women and Girls:** Diplomatically, Slovenia will make Afghanistan's women a central theme of Council discussions. In the short term, that means leading on statements that condemn the latest Taliban decrees and **demand access to education and work for women**. Slovenia can initiate an emergency UNSC **press statement or meeting focused exclusively on women's rights in Afghanistan**, ensuring the issue stays in the international spotlight. It will also support the renewal and strengthening of UNAMA's **mandate to monitor human rights** and report on abuses against women

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. Concurrently, Slovenia will work with partner states to amplify Afghan women's voices – for instance, arranging for Afghan women activists to brief the Council (even if only via video from exile, given many cannot speak freely at home). By keeping global attention on gender apartheid in Afghanistan, Slovenia aims to pressure the Taliban to rethink their most draconian policies.

- **No Recognition, But Active Engagement:** In the short term, Slovenia will **refuse any move toward recognizing the Taliban regime**. However, it will encourage *pragmatic engagement* through the U.N. framework. Slovenia supports the U.N.'s **"Doha format" talks** that bring together international envoys and Taliban officials in an informal setting

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. Slovenia could offer to participate or provide expertise in these talks, particularly on humanitarian logistics or human rights benchmarks. Importantly, Slovenia will coordinate with the EU to ensure a unified message: the Taliban must earn any legitimacy through actions, not words

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. Short-term engagement will focus on **confidence-building measures** – e.g. advocating for the Taliban to allow polio vaccination campaigns countrywide, or to cooperate on locating and clearing landmines. These are apolitical issues where cooperation could save lives and build a modicum of trust.

- **Leverage Frozen Assets for Aid:** An immediate economic measure Slovenia champions is unlocking frozen Afghan funds for humanitarian use. Many countries hold Afghan central bank assets frozen since 2021

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. Slovenia proposes that the UNSC **authorize a mechanism** (possibly through a U.N. trust fund) to use a portion of those funds to purchase critical supplies – grain, medicines, power generators – which would be delivered directly to Afghanistan's people under U.N.

supervisionfile-5qtbsnewp7oqv1u5ouacvj. This would inject resources to alleviate suffering without handing cash to the Taliban. Such an initiative could be time-bound and reviewed regularly. In parallel, Slovenia will encourage international financial institutions to **offer basic technical support** to Afghanistan (for example, helping maintain the electricity grid or drought mitigation) under monitoring, so that humanitarian infrastructure does not completely erode.

- **Diplomatic Coordination:** In the UNSC, Slovenia will work closely with both Western allies and regional powers to keep consensus. This means consulting with countries like China, Russia, and India – who have stakes in Afghan stability – to find common ground on humanitarian objectives even if political views diverge. Slovenia can use its bridging capacity as an EU member that also engages with non-Western states to craft resolutions that all can support (e.g. emphasizing aid and counterterrorism, which everyone agrees on). In the short term, a concrete diplomatic step could be a **UNSC presidential statement** (which requires unanimity) reaffirming support for Afghanistan’s people, calling for women’s rights, and underscoring that the Council’s measures (sanctions, etc.) are not intended to harm civilians. Securing such a statement with all 15 members – including those typically sympathetic to the Taliban – would be a notable achievement in unity.

Long-Term Strategies (Sustainable Solutions)

- **Conditional Engagement Roadmap:** Slovenia envisions the development of a **long-term roadmap** for engaging any Afghan authorities, tied strictly to benchmarks. In the UNSC, Slovenia will support the U.N. Secretary-General’s effort to create a **“pathway to recognition” document** – essentially a list of conditions and steps the Taliban (or any future Afghan government) must meet to gain gradual acceptance

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. These conditions would include forming a more inclusive government, upholding fundamental human rights (especially for women and minorities), renouncing terrorism, and respecting international law. The process would lay out what the international community would offer in return for each major step (for example, the sequence might be: reopen secondary schools for girls **nationwide**, then certain sanctions are lifted or development projects resume). This approach gives the Taliban a clear choice and timeline, and it keeps international engagement principled over the long run. Slovenia would contribute its expertise in international law to ensure the roadmap’s benchmarks align with global norms and Slovenia’s values.

- **Sustainable Economic Development:** For the long term, Slovenia will promote strategies aimed at moving Afghanistan from dependency to self-reliance – **but only if governance improves**. A key part of this is regional economic integration. Slovenia, through the EU and U.N., can facilitate dialogue on including Afghanistan in regional trade initiatives like the **Central Asia-South Asia power project (CASA-1000)** or transport corridors linking Central Asia to South Asia. In Council discussions, Slovenia can highlight projects such as **railways connecting Uzbekistan and Pakistan via Afghanistan**, or expanding Iran’s Chabahar port access for Afghan trade

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, as future opportunities if stability returns. The idea is to give Afghans a stake in a peaceful, law-abiding future economy. Likewise, tapping Afghanistan’s vast mineral resources (copper, lithium, rare earths) could greatly benefit the country, but Slovenia will insist this must be done

transparently and with protections in place – perhaps under U.N. or multilateral development bank oversight – to ensure profits help the Afghan people and not just a few. Long-term, once basic conditions are met, Slovenia would support the **resumption of development aid** and investment in Afghanistan’s infrastructure (roads, schools, clean water, renewable energy) to lift the country out of protracted crisis. Any such aid would be conditional on inclusivity – for instance, infrastructure projects should hire local labor including women, and education aid must include girls’ schooling.

- **Human Rights Mechanisms:** Slovenia will work to institutionalize human rights oversight for the long haul. This includes continuing the mandate of the U.N. Special Rapporteur on Afghanistan and potentially establishing a **Commission of Inquiry** or strengthening the role of the International Criminal Court regarding Afghanistan if crimes against humanity (like gender persecution) continue. While accountability may not come swiftly, documenting abuses now builds the case for future justice. Slovenia’s commitment to **Responsibility to Protect (R2P)** principles means it will remind the UNSC that the international community has a duty to protect populations from mass atrocity crimes

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. If the situation in Afghanistan were to further deteriorate into widespread atrocity (for example, targeted violence against an ethnic group or mass famine inflicted by policy), Slovenia would advocate for R2P discussions – though any action would require careful international deliberation. In the long term, improving human rights also involves Afghan civil society. Thus, Slovenia will push for **programs that support Afghan civil society actors, journalists, and women’s groups**, even if they must operate from exile for now. The UNSC can encourage U.N. agencies to fund educational and leadership programs for Afghan women and youth (e.g. scholarships abroad, regional training) so that an entire generation is not lost. These investments in people are part of a long-term bet on Afghanistan’s future beyond the current regime.

- **Future Diplomatic Framework:** Recognizing that the Taliban’s hold on power may evolve, Slovenia supports exploring a **future political settlement in Afghanistan**. In the long run, stability may require an internal dialogue among Afghans – including the Taliban, other political factions, ethnic leaders, and the diaspora – to chart a more inclusive governance structure. While this is ultimately for Afghans to decide, the U.N. can facilitate when the time is ripe. Slovenia would back a U.N.-led **peace process or loya jirga (grand assembly)** format if moderate elements emerge or if there is internal push for a new constitutional order. In preparation, Slovenia will engage with Afghanistan’s neighbors and major powers to form a **contact group** that can swiftly support any nascent peace efforts. The long-term diplomatic vision is to reintegrate a reformed Afghanistan into the international community – including eventually returning an accredited government to the U.N. seat – but only after it adheres to international standards. Until then, Slovenia will maintain the principled stance of **“help the Afghan people, pressure the Taliban regime.”** This balanced approach in the Council keeps hope alive that Afghanistan’s crisis can one day be resolved through sustained international support and Afghan-led change.

By combining these short-term and long-term strategies, Slovenia aims to address immediate suffering while not losing sight of Afghanistan's future. This comprehensive plan ensures that in all Security Council deliberations, Slovenia will advocate for the Afghan people's welfare and rights, insist on conditions for the Taliban's engagement, and contribute to a unified international approach to one of the world's most challenging crises. Through steadfast commitment to its values – human rights, peace, and development – Slovenia will help steer the Council toward actions that alleviate the humanitarian crisis today and foster a more stable, inclusive Afghanistan tomorrow.